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Music 650 - Creative Musical coding
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David Behrman concert report

David Behrman's concert at Issue project room was one of my, if not my favorite concert that I have been to in recent years. The innovative nature of his work was really thrilling to see live, as well as the varied and cinematic performance methods. His mastery of harmonies, additive synthesis, and unconventional musical tactics all culminated in a really magnificent live performance.

I thought the first piece played was really amazing musically, as well as visually. The musical elements were very well thought out, and hearing the transformations of the tone generators was super interesting live. Several times I heard waves transform from simple beating rhythms to large swirling tones and back again. However, his sense of harmony still managed to sneak its way into such a complexly changing piece. While not as harmonically focused as some of his other work, you could tell as a listener how much effort and thought went into the adjustable parameters of the tone generators. This resulted in an undulating harmonic mass, yet it rarely, if ever, sounded "wrong". However; what I thought was most impressive is that while achieving such an amazing audio experience, the visual experience of watching the performance was just as good. Shutting off the lights while sitting in an old theater and using flashlights to control the piece really put a good spectacle together. I firmly believe that part of a good live music performance is the visual element, the spectacle. This piece really embodied that and it was a delight to watch.

Even after singing such high praise of the first piece, the second piece was even better. The harmonic, rhythmic, and all around musical content was amazing. I do think the first one had a better visual element, but the second still provided good visual content for the audience. The harmonic content in this piece was masterful. The subtlety that Behrman achieved in his harmonies and the changes of them was infinitely impressive and inspiring. Behrman created such a lush yet delicate musical foundation for the percussionist to shine through the generators he was manipulating. I think the harmonic foundation laid down by Behrman was nice enough to be a long form piece in its own right, maybe closer in style to something of Phil Niblock or James Tenney. However, the varied percussion accompaniment was really the star of the show. I cannot even remember how many percussion sounds we heard, but each was tasteful, new, and a delight to hear. The delaying of certain percussion sounds that Behrman was doing with his dual delay max patch added a whole other level to the richness, complexity, and rhythmic awesomeness. I do believe that the first piece had a better spectacle factor with the dark room and flashlights. But that being said, it was really fun to suddenly hear a new percussion sound and scramble to see what instrument or object was being played before it was set down to never be heard from again. I found that race to see what was being played a really entertaining and playful visual element that I thought complimented the nature of the piece well.

All in all it was a truly wonderful experience, and meeting Behrman after was the cherry on top. Awesome concert, I would watch it again in a heartbeat.